

The Weather Station at Cape Marrow

A document written to be highlighted. Nothing in it refers to a real place, person or system.

One — The station

The weather station at Cape Marrow was built in the spring of nineteen sixty-two, on a shelf of rock that the sea had spent a long time deciding not to take. It was a low building with a flat roof, painted a grey that the salt turned white within two winters, and it held four rooms: an instrument room, a radio room, a kitchen, and a room with two beds in it that nobody had ever called a bedroom.

The first keeper was a man named Aldous Renn. He had asked for the posting in a letter of eleven lines, and the whole of his argument was in the last of them: *I would like to be somewhere where the readings matter more than the reader.* The board that appointed him found this either very modest or very arrogant, and could not agree which, and so gave him the job.

Renn kept the station for nineteen years. In that time he recorded the temperature four times a day, the barometric pressure four times a day, the wind speed and direction on the hour, and the sea state whenever he could see the sea. He missed eleven readings in nineteen years. Nine of those were in one week in February of nineteen seventy-four, when the roof came off.

Two — The notebooks

What made the Cape Marrow record valuable was not the instruments, which were ordinary, but the notebooks. Renn wrote in the margins. Beside a pressure reading he would note that the gulls had gone inland; beside a temperature he would note that the kettle had boiled slow. None of this was asked for and none of it was in the format the service wanted.

For thirty years it was regarded as clutter. Then a graduate student named Ilse Vandermeer, who was looking for something else entirely, noticed that the marginal notes predicted the readings. The gulls went inland eight to fourteen hours before the pressure fell. The kettle boiled slow on mornings when the air was heavier than the barometer had yet admitted. Renn had been recording a second instrument the whole time, and the instrument was the coast itself.

Vandermeer's paper is nine pages long and contains one sentence that gets quoted more than the rest: *An observation that does not fit the form is not therefore noise*. It is a sentence about weather stations, and people have used it to mean almost anything.

Three — What the record is for

The station was automated in nineteen eighty-one and closed in two thousand and four. The instruments were sent to a store in the capital, the building was sold, and the notebooks went to a university library where they sat uncatalogued for a decade.

There is a copy of every page now. The copies are what people work from, because the originals have a problem the copies do not: Renn wrote in pencil, and pencil moves. Every time a page is handled, a little of the record leaves it. The library's rule is that the original is consulted only to settle a dispute about the copy, and in twenty years that has happened twice.

Both times the copy was right.